THE DOCTRINE OF CHRIST

WHAT IS DOCTRINE?

The word doctrine is derived from the Greek word 'didache' which denotes either the act of teaching or that which is being taught.

Doctrine is:

1. A principle or body of principles presented for acceptance or belief, as by a religious, political, scientific, or philosophic group; dogma.
2. A rule or principle of law, especially when established by precedent.
3. A statement of official government policy especially in foreign affairs and military strategy.
4. Archaic: Something taught; a teaching.

(Middle English, from old French, from Latin doctrina, from doctor, teacher; see doctor).

- Synonyms: doctrine, dogma, tenet.

  These nouns denote a principle taught, advanced, or accepted, as by a group of philosophers, the legal doctrine of due process; church dogma; experimentation, one of the tenets of the physical sciences.

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Doctrine is:

1. rule or principle: a rule or principle that forms the basis of a belief, theory, or policy
2. ideas taught as truth: a body of ideas, particularly in religion, taught to people as truthful or correct

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Doctrine is also a language and concept used in military circles. Understanding how they use it will help us appreciate further its use and importance in the scriptures.

Military doctrine is the concise expression of how military forces contribute to campaigns, major operations, battles, and engagements.

It is a guide to action, not hard and fast rules. Doctrine provides a common frame of reference across the military. It helps standardize operations, facilitating readiness by establishing common ways of accomplishing military tasks.

Doctrine links theory, history, experimentation, and practice. Its objective is to foster initiative and creative thinking. Doctrine provides the military an authoritative body of statements on how military forces conduct operations and provides a common lexicon for use by military planners and leaders. (*Wikipedia)*

Military doctrine is the fundamental principles by which the military forces or elements thereof guide their actions in support of national objectives. It is authoritative but requires judgment in application.

(Doctrine of Military and Associated Terms. US Department of Defence 2005)

What general principles can we deduce about doctrine?

Here are some of the general principles that we can deduce from the definitions of doctrine stated above.

1. Although doctrine is authoritative, it requires judgment in its application.
2. Doctrine fosters initiative and creative thinking.
3. It is not a set of rules but a guide to action in the accomplishment of tasks.
4. It facilitates readiness: it helps you to know the set processes and procedures, and establishes rules of behaviour in doing things.
5. Doctrine with training will produce discipline.
6. Doctrine will produce the same vocabulary and the same language among a given people.

WHAT IS THE DOCTRINE OF CHRIST?

In the light of the understanding of doctrine that is stated above, we can attempt some definitions of the doctrine of Christ.

- The *doctrine of Christ* is the principle or body of principles or ideas that were taught by our Lord Jesus Christ as truths which should form the basis of belief and practices in the church *(e.g., Matthew 5:43-45)*.
- It is the fundamental principles of God that guided the teachings, actions and activities of our Lord Jesus Christ, in His pursuit, and fulfilment of the objectives of God and His kingdom on earth. *(e.g., John 9:3-5; John 3:16-18; 8:3-12)*.

According to our Lord Jesus Christ, His doctrine is not His, but God's, who sent Him; therefore the *doctrine of Christ* is the doctrine of God.

> *"Jesus answered them and said, My doctrine is not Mine, but His that sent Me. If anyone wills to do His will, He shall know concerning the doctrine, whether it is from God or whether I speak on My own authority" - John 7:16-17 (The Good News Translation).*

- The *doctrine of Christ* is not a body of regulations or a set of rules. It is meant to provide a framework for the church (the ecclesia) which is God's representative on the earth. The doctrine encompasses God's plan of redemption, the execution and fulfilment of that plan through our Lord Jesus Christ, the emergence of the church and the fulfilment of her purpose until the redemption of the purchased possession.

Ephesians 1:1-11. Verses 4-7 show the blessings that accrue to God's elect, while *verses 8-11*, show us that God had a plan of redemption and this plan was hidden in Him but has now been revealed. And that the purpose of this plan is to bring together all things in heaven and earth in Christ. In other words this plan seeks to reconcile all things in heaven and on earth to God through Jesus Christ the Lord.

- The *doctrine of Christ* brings together and connects from the fall of man, the processes and steps that lead up to the incarnation of our Lord Jesus Christ, His death, burial, resurrection, ascension and the hope of His return. It also includes the advent of the Holy Spirit, the emergence of the church, and the fulfilment of her purpose until God gathers together all creation, everything in heaven and on earth, with Christ as the head. The plan of redemption invariably leads to God's eternal judgment.

> *"This plan, which God will complete when the time is right, is to bring all creation together, everything in heaven and on earth, with Christ as head. All things are done according to God's plan and decision; and God chose us to be his own people in union with Christ because of his own purpose, based on what he had decided from the very beginning", - Ephesians 1; 10, 11 (The Good News Translation).*

As we approach this study, we must determine within ourselves that we are willing to do what God wants and not what the world wants. That desire and determination to do the will of God will help us to discern and know the doctrine of Christ and the certainty that it comes from God.

> *"Whoever is willing to do what God wants will know whether what I teach comes from God or whether I speak on my own authority" - John 7:17 (The Good News Translation).*

> *"If you really want to obey God, you will know if what I teach comes from God or from me."- John 7:17 (The Good News Translation).*

Make this bold declaration with desire and determination.

- I will do the will of God.
- It is my choice to do the will of God.
- I am determined to do the will of God.
- The Spirit of the Lord will show me clearly the authentic doctrine of Christ
- Therefore I know certainly that it is from God.

WHY THE STUDY OF THE DOCTRINE OF CHRIST IS VERY IMPORTANT

1. The new creation or the believer will not come into perfection or maturity, if he still holds on to the doctrine of the world.
2. When Jesus taught His disciples to pray in *Matthew 6:9, 10*, He said "Our father in heaven, hallowed be your name, your kingdom come, your will be done on earth as it is heaven". This tells us that it is God's desire and will for His government to be on earth, for things to be done on earth as it is done in heaven.

But the will of heaven cannot be produced on earth without *heaven's doctrine* (the doctrine of Christ) being known and communicated to men effectively, and men receiving it and allowing it change their lives.

When *God's doctrine* comes, it comes to bless. When God's word comes, it comes as rain to bless. Heaven wants to bless but cannot do so without doctrine. Doctrine is what positions you for the blessing or the curse, *(Deuteronomy 32:1, 2; Isaiah 55:10, 11; Hebrews 6:7, 8; James 1:21-25)*.

3. We are living in a time when divers and strange doctrines are constantly being churned out: teachings and practices that are completely foreign and alien to the nature and character of Christ. Today, we see the lives of many believers in Christ being regulated, controlled and driven by these doctrines and are completely unaware that they are being led away from the grace of Christ. We are all prone to being carried away by these strange doctrines, if we do not know and become established in the doctrine of Christ, *(Hebrews 13:9; Galatians 1:6-10; 1Timothy 4:1-3)*.
4. It will help us to rediscover, in the midst of the various teachings, practices, rites and rituals in today's church, the authentic gospel of Christ, and contend for it *(Jude 3, Galatians 1:6-9)*.
5. As we embark on this study will help us to appreciate the benefits (such as, salvation, infilling of the Holy Spirit etc) and responsibilities of our redemption in Christ Jesus (Such as, being holy as God is holy, shining as God's light in the world etc).
6. Since doctrine shapes our thoughts, beliefs, actions, and behaviour, when we know and embrace the doctrine of Christ, it will shape our thoughts, beliefs, actions and behaviour. This will inevitably produce unity of faith – unity of thoughts, hearts, mission, purpose, and motivation. This is not the same thing as uniformity of actions and activities, *(Ephesians 4:13-16; Philippians 2:2, 19-23)*.
7. The gospel of Christ is the power of God for salvation and in it the righteousness of God is revealed. The gospel of God is capable of saving any man who embraces it from Satan, sin, and this evil world. It reveals to man the details of how to walk and function in the kingdom of God.
8. To have God, one must have the doctrine of Christ *(2 John9)*, whosoever transgresses and does not have the doctrine of Christ does not have God.

9. We should withdraw from anyone who professes faith in the Lord Jesus Christ and does not uphold the doctrine of Christ *(2 John 9 &10)*.
10. The doctrine of Christ is the foundation and the superstructure of the Christian faith; it is the beginning, the heart and the end of our faith (*Matthew 16:18; Hebrews 12:1*).

THE UNIQUE NATURE AND CHARACTER OF THE DOCTRINE OF CHRIST

The Uniqueness of the Doctrine of Christ

In the first study, we defined the word 'Doctrine' and then we used the understanding that we got from that definition to craft the definition of 'The Doctrine of Christ'. From there we progressed to look at 'Why the Study on the Doctrine of Christ is Very Important'.

In the days of Jesus' ministry on earth, we were told that *"…The people were astonished at His doctrine" (Matthew 7:28; 22:33)*. What was it about the doctrine of Christ that astonished the people? The people observed that it was different from that of the religious leaders of His day. He did not teach like them. He did not teach what they taught and the *fruit* of His doctrine was different.

We must not forget that so many sages have appeared on the stage of human history and have taught profound and stimulating doctrines about God and life, yet Jesus' doctrine surpasses them all.

In this study, we shall be seeking to establish from the scriptures the qualities that make the doctrine of Christ outstanding and matchless. Please note, that we shall neither be examining Jesus Christ as a person, nor shall we be studying the qualities in themselves. Our focus is to highlight the qualities in the doctrine of Christ that make it unique.

UNIQUE QUALITIES OF THE DOCTRINE OF CHRIST:

LOVE

Inherent in the doctrine of Christ is love. He taught that the greatest commandment is to love God with all your heart, your soul and your mind, and to love your neighbour as yourself, *(Matthew 22:36-40)*.

a) The Love of God:

Jesus began demonstrating His love for God the father as early in life as age 12, when He chose to stay back in Jerusalem, and was found in the temple, asking and answering questions among the doctors of the law, rather than being with His parents and His company *(Luke 2:42-50)*. He demonstrated His love for God the Father by His obedience

to the Father's command, *(John 14:31).* His readiness to lay down His life for the sheep and take it up again was also an expression of His love for the Father because it was a commandment He had received from the Father, *(John 10:18).* Jesus did only those things that were pleasing to the Father, *(John 8:29).* He loved God implicitly and unreservedly. This is reflected in His doctrine.

b) Love of Man:

The same love that flowed from God, the Father, flowed to Jesus Christ, and from Him to us *(John 15:9-12)*. There is no greater love than the love of Jesus Christ, for He said, *"Greater love has no man than this, than to lay down one's life for his friends."(John 15:13).* He is the good shepherd, who lays down His life for the sheep, *(John 10:11).* Jesus demonstrated His love for us by dying for us, even while we were sinners, *(Romans 5:6-8).* Speaking to His disciples, He said, *"A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another; as I have loved you, that you also love one another"(John 13:34).* Jesus caped it up by stating categorically that the distinguishing quality of His followers is the love that they have for one another.

Matthew 5: 10-12

It is because of the love of God that we can willingly suffer persecution as Disciples of Christ.

Matthew 5: 21-24.

Inherent in the doctrine of Christ is the love of God. The character behind this instruction is the love of God. What is motivating it is the love of God, not just the love of man.

Matthew 5:31

Within this teaching, is the love of man because of his love for God?

Matthew 5:38-48.

It is because of this implicit love of God that we are able to love as the Father loves. The implicit, uncompromising love of God implies complete focus on God. Inherent in this doctrine is love. An outflow of this love is the love for the people to whom He (Jesus) has been sent.

Inherent in *Matthew 5:3 - 7:26,* is the love of God: TAKE AWAY THAT QUALITY OR CHARACTER OF LOVE FOR GOD from teachings such as "blessed are the poor in spirit"; "blessed are they who mourn" and the teachings will not make sense.

LIGHT (John 8:12; 9:5; 12:46)

Another inherent quality of the doctrine of Christ is light. His doctrine gives illumination. It exposes the things that are hidden and makes clear that which was hitherto unclear *(Ephesians 5:13; John 3:16-21)*. It exposes that which is evil and reveals that which is right. In *John 8:1-11*, when the Scribes and the Pharisees came to Jesus on account of the woman caught in adultery, they affirmed that Moses commanded that such should be stoned. But they asked Him, what do you say? This question was about His doctrine on the issue. Jesus' response exposed the secret sins of the woman's accusers, pricked their consciences and revealed God's attitude towards sinners. In just one conversation with the woman at the well at Samaria in *John 4:6-29*: Jesus revealed the woman's past and present marital status; His identity, as the Christ; God's perception of the worship of Samaritans; the nature of God; and the venue for true worship, (which is, in Spirit and in truth). Evidently, the woman received understanding from the conversation she had with Jesus, because she immediately ran to tell the men of the city of Samaria to come and see the man that told her all she ever did.

LIFE: (John 1:1-5; 5:39, 40; 12:49, 50; Mark 1:21-28; 5:1:1-15; Acts 13:7-12)

Innate in the doctrine of Christ is the life of God. Jesus said, the words that I speak to you are spirit and life *(John 6:63)*. It is the life that is in His doctrine that transforms lives.

The doctrine of Christ transforms the lives of those who believe it (John 5:24). What we see with His disciples is a clear example of this fact: Ignorant and uneducated men, such as Peter and John who were mere fishermen became bold and confident public speakers of God's word as a result of being with Jesus *(Acts 4:13)*. Mary, once notorious for her sinful lifestyle came in contact with Jesus, when He was speaking in the house of Simon the Pharisee; she became a disciple to whom Jesus would first reveal Himself after His resurrection, *(John12:3-8; Luke 7:37-39; John 20:11-17)*. Zacchaeus, a tax collector climbed on a tree to see and hear Jesus. After one encounter with Jesus, he confessed His sins and made a commitment to return everything He had acquired by extortion (Luke 19:1-10).It is impossible to receive the doctrine of Christ and remain the same. For He declared, "He that hears my words and believes in Him that sent me, has everlasting life, and shall not come into condemnation; but is passed from death unto life". His doctrine produces a metamorphosis in those who receive it and believe it. It is because of this change that they become capable of living holy and righteous lives while still in the flesh. Peter, one of His disciples declared that He had the words of eternal life *(John 6:68)*.

Beyond this, Jesus declared that the dead shall hear His voice (the Son of God), and live *(John 5:25)*: Such was the case of – A dead little girl who heard Him say *`Talitha cumi'* and lived *(Mark 5:41& 42)*; Lazarus, who after four days in the grave, heard Jesus call his name and came back to life *(John 11:43, 44);* the widow's dead son at Nain, also heard Jesus' voice and lived *(Luke 7:11-15)*. The doctrine of Christ carried divine life.

The doctrine of Christ is life. It has the ability to transform lives into the image of Christ.

TRUTH (John 1:17; 17:17).

John the Baptist testified that truth came through Jesus Christ. The doctrine of Christ is truth in content and character. His doctrine was not based on lies, nor was it deceptive. This was attested to by Peter, one of His foremost apostles. *(1 Peter 2:21, 22)*.

Integrity of heart and purpose:

He spoke the truth at all times in spite of the price He had to pay for it. Jesus did not hide from His disciples the price that they would have to pay for following Him *(John5:53-59),*

Jesus spoke from the integrity of His heart, even when His teachings were offensive to the people He did not adjust it in order to be popular. He was not in a popularity contest nor was He a man pleaser.

Jesus spoke truth in the inward parts *(Psalm 51:6)*.

He spoke in the open and did nothing in hiding; He lived and taught very openly before His disciples and the people *(John 3:18; 18:20)*.

Ultimate reality:

His doctrine reveals God: who is a Spirit and the reality of his kingdom which is also spiritual. This is the ultimate reality-This is truth. It is different from physical reality or fact. Spiritual reality is superior to physical reality and Jesus taught and spoke from that reality *(John 18:36-38).*

The doctrine of Christ points us to spiritual realities. For instance, *(Matthew 8:17)*, says "... He Himself took our infirmities, and bore our sicknesses"- this is a spiritual reality. But the fact on the ground could be that we are feeling sick in our bodies. If we believe the spiritual reality, that God has taken our infirmities and borne our sicknesses, then the fact on ground, which is, the sickness that we are feeling in our bodies, must leave. And the spiritual reality will stand – causing our bodies to be healed.

He is truth Himself:

In His doctrine, He declared "...I am the Way, the Truth and the Life" *(John 14:6),* indicating that His doctrine is the absolute truth; He is the embodiment of the truth and the end of man's search for the truth.

5. DIVINE AUTHORITY (Hebrews 1:1-3; Mark 1:27, 29, Luke 4:32).

The doctrine of Christ is characterized with divine authority. The Lord Jesus spoke as the vicegerent of God. *(John 14: 8-10).* This means that He spoke as God's representative on earth. In other words, He was the voice of God, the oracle (mouthpiece) of God on the earth. He would say, "...you have heard that it was said to those of old ... but I say..." *(Matthew 5:21, 27, 31, 33, 38, and 43)*. He spoke as one with divine authority. He spoke as one who knew God. He spoke as one who came from God *(John 3:10-13)*. Jesus shows here that the source of His authority was His intimacy with heaven.

Jesus exercised authority in heaven, on earth (*Mark 4: 41*) and over the forces of darkness *(Mark 7:28, 29; 5:1-10)*. The authority of His doctrine is one of the things that stand it out in comparison with all other doctrines. In *Mark 5:1-13*: we ca n see that even the demons recognized this divine authority.

6. HONOUR (John 5:41-44,).

His doctrine did not seek honour from men. He did not seek to draw attention or affection to Himself, for Himself, but to God who sent Him, *John 6:35 -39*. He sought to honour God and sought the honour that comes from God. So when He was reviled He did not revile back or abuse His authority to get honour from men. He subjected Himself to the will of God *(Luke 22:49-54; Matthew 26:47-53)*.

7. LIBERTY (James 1:25; John 1:3; 2 Timothy 2:9).

The doctrine of Christ promotes the exercise of a man's freewill in the service and worship of God. Jesus said that, whosoever He sets free, is free and free indeed *(John 8:36)*. This is a remarkable quality of the doctrine of Christ that separates it from others. Think about this, He took men (His disciples) who were steep in Judaism which was filled with so many rites and rituals given by God and brought them into the way of eternal life leaving them with only two sacraments – communion *(Luke 22:14-20)* and baptism *(Mark 16:15, 16)*. See His handling of a few controversies that the religious leaders of His day threw at Him: The question of fasting *(Matthew 9:14, 15)*; Sabbath *(Matthew 12:1-8)*; paying tax to Caesar *(Matthew 22:15-22)*; divorce in marriage *(Matthew 19:3-9)* and so on. We see that rather than give His own long list of do's and don'ts, He teaches us to exercise our freewill and LOVE God with all our heart, soul and might,*(Matthew 22:34-40)*. We will have to make the choice to believe. Some confuse the liberty that Jesus gives with liberalism (A belief in tolerance and gradual reform in moral, religious, or political matters). They are not the same. They as far apart as the east is from the west or the North Pole are from the South Pole.

8. TRANSPARENCY (John 1:35-42; 15:15; 18:19, 20)

Jesus lived his life in the open among His disciples. He taught and showed them all that the He heard from the Father. He had no hidden agendas. His disciples and all that heard Him were free to ask Him questions and obtain answers from Him. This shows that He was accountable. When He was questioned about His doctrine: He did not get offended, but explained, using the Old Testament scriptures, and was willing to be judged based on His works *(John 10:30-38)*.

On account of His transparency in doctrine, Jesus abhorred hypocrisy.

He often confronted the hypocrisy of the religious leaders of his day, (*Matthew 23:1-36)*. He particularly, warned His disciples to beware of the doctrine of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy *(Luke 12:1; Mark 12:38-40; Matthew 16:6-12)*. The Pharisees and the scribes would teach the people the laws of Moses but they themselves would not keep the laws. But Jesus was different: hear what the writer of the book of Acts says about Jesus, in His summarization of the Gospel of Luke "... All that Jesus began both to do and teach" *(Acts1:1)*. This shows us that the teachings of Jesus were essentially from what He was doing. In His doctrine, Jesus taught that he who breaks the commandments of God and teaches others to do them shall be called least, in the kingdom of God. But he who does the commandments of God and teaches others to do so shall be called great, in the kingdom of God *(Matthew 5:19)*. In very unmistakable terms, Jesus' doctrine forbade hypocrisy.